

The Noble Dharma Teaching Called 'The Vast Meaning'

Ārya-arthavistara-nāma-dharmaparyāya · Toh 318 · Derge Kangyur

འཕགས་པ་དེའི་རྒྱ་པ་ཞེས་བ་བྱའི་ཆོས་ཀྱི་

The Noble Synonym of Dharma Called "The Vast Meaning," known in Sanskrit as the Ārya-arthavistara-nāma-dharmaparyāya and in Tibetan as Pakpa Dön Gyépa Zhéjawa'i Chö Kyi Rgyacher Röpa, is a sūtra in which the Venerable Śāriputra, at the Buddha's residence in Jeta Grove near Śrāvastī, expounds to the assembled monks a teaching described as wholesome throughout — in its beginning, middle, and end — and that illuminates the holy life through an extended enumeration of synonyms for the Dharma. The text belongs to the genre of dharmaparyāya, or Dharma discourse, a form concerned with conveying the Buddha's teaching in richly elaborated terms. It is Toh 318 in the Kangyur, the collection of canonical texts attributed to the Buddha, and was translated into Tibetan by the monk Yeshé Dé, one of the foremost translators of the early transmission period.

— and it was translated, edited, and established by the great editor and translator, the monk Yeshé Dé.

In the language of India: Ārya-arthavistara-nāma-dharmaparyāya.

In the Tibetan language: The Noble Synonym of Dharma Called "The Vast Meaning."

Homage to all buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear at one time. The Blessed One was dwelling at Śrāvastī in the Jeta Grove, the garden of Anāthapiṇḍada, in the palace of the prince Jeta.

Then the Venerable Śāriputra addressed the monks: "Venerable ones, I shall teach you a Dharma that is wholesome in the beginning, wholesome in the middle, and wholesome at the end — of excellent meaning, of excellent words, unmixed, perfectly complete, perfectly pure, perfectly clarified — which reveals the holy life. It is this: the synonym of Dharma called 'The Vast Meaning.' Hear it well, take it to heart, and I shall speak." And he spoke.

"What, then, is the synonym of Dharma of 'The Vast Meaning'? Venerable ones, these twelve gatherings of leisure are conditions through which the noble Dharma is obtained. They are as follows: one's own endowments; the endowments of others; being human; being born in a central land; having faculties that are complete and unimpaired; not having committed actions at

the extreme; coming to have faith in the [right] place; the arising of buddhas; the teaching of the holy Dharma; the continued abiding of those who have taught the Dharma; those who abide in it taking it up in practice; and inspiring heartfelt compassion in others. Thus, venerable ones, these twelve gatherings of leisure are conditions through which the noble Dharma is obtained.

Venerable ones, a monk who is a speaker should speak to others in twenty ways. They are as follows: at the right time; with respect; in a fitting manner; with proper occasion and connection; with illustration; with enthusiasm, with satisfaction, and with delight; without disparagement; with reason and relevance; without rambling; with a mind of integrity; with benefit; with a mind of benefit; with a mind of loving care; independent of gain, honor, and verse. When speaking these words, one should not praise oneself or disparage others, but simply speak.

Venerable ones, one who wishes to listen to the Dharma should listen in sixteen ways. They are as follows: to listen to the Dharma at the right time; to show honor; to listen respectfully; to be free from dissatisfaction; to listen as one has been instructed; not to seek out faults; to hold the Dharma in reverence; to hold the person teaching the Dharma in reverence; not to despise the Dharma; not to despise the person teaching the Dharma; not to despise oneself; with a one-pointed mind; with a mind intent on knowing everything; listening with ears wide open; gathering the mind, and, with all of one's mind, attending to the Dharma in thought.

When one listens to the Dharma rightly in this way, faith arises and the mind becomes clear toward nirvāṇa as the supreme aim. Supreme joy and delight arise in the mind toward nirvāṇa as the supreme aim. Joy free from attachment arises toward nirvāṇa as the supreme aim. The proximate afflictions are abandoned, the mind is placed in equanimity, doubts are cleared away, and views are made straight — all through nirvāṇa as the supreme aim. The mind becomes unified in yoga, becomes fit, applies effort, abandons, is correctly settled within, and arrives at the supreme meaning — through nirvāṇa as the supreme aim. All formations are pacified; one focuses on emptiness; craving is exhausted; attachment is abandoned; cessation is beheld; and toward nirvāṇa the mind fully enters, becomes clear, properly abides, and is completely liberated — through nirvāṇa as the supreme aim."

Through nirvāṇa as the supreme aim, the mind fully enters, becomes clear, properly abides, and is completely liberated in regard to the aggregates being

impermanent, the aggregates being accumulated, the aggregates being nourished, the aggregates being without essence, and the aggregates being subject to dissolution.

Through nirvāṇa as the supreme aim, the eye becomes perfectly purified so as to know the Four Noble Truths.

Through nirvāṇa as the supreme aim, liberation is completely and fully realized.

Venerable ones, if a noble śrāvaka listens to the Dharma in this way — correctly and as it truly is — he will no longer be enthralled by mere noise or prattle; he will taste the flavor of the Dharma's discourse; he will honor the Teacher in accordance with the nature of reality; he will pursue his own benefit; and he will attain nirvāṇa.

These are the qualities through which his wisdom becomes fully ripened: relying upon a spiritual friend (kalyāṇamitra) while dwelling in a wholesome manner and possessing a wholesome character; having a mind endowed with wisdom; being easy to instruct; listening with respect; inquiring thoroughly; hearing the sublime Dharma; practicing the sublime Dharma constantly; cultivating weariness toward those things that are properly objects of weariness; in the same way, attending with proper mental engagement to complete weariness; abandoning all unwholesome qualities and properly establishing oneself in wholesome qualities; and achieving purification, gaining mastery in meditative absorption (samādhi), and engaging in proper mental attention.

Venerable ones, a noble śrāvaka who has engaged in such proper and correct mental attention should cultivate these ten perceptions: the perception of the unattractive, the perception of impermanence, the perception of suffering in what is impermanent, the perception of no-self in suffering, the perception of food being unsuitable, the perception of non-delight in the entire world, the perception of luminosity, the perception of freedom from attachment, the perception of cessation, and the perception of death.

Venerable ones, there are fourteen qualities that interrupt the perception of the unattractive: dwelling together with women; gazing at women with distracted mindfulness; heedlessness; having strong attachment; pursuing signs of the attractive; failing to reflect distinctly on what is impure; associating with persons who have entered upon the extreme of conduct; conforming to them; not listening with respect; not inquiring thoroughly;

failing to guard the doors of the sense faculties; not knowing moderation in food; having no delight in seclusion; and failing to reflect on things as they truly are.

What interrupts the perception of impermanence is attachment to formations.

The qualities that interrupt the perception of suffering in what is impermanent are six: laziness, remorse, dissipation, heedlessness, lack of effort, and failure to reflect on things as they truly are.

What interrupts the perception of no-self in suffering is the view of self.

What interrupts the perception of food being unsuitable is craving for flavor.

What interrupts the perception of non-delight in the entire world is aspiration and attachment to the various things of the world.

The qualities that interrupt the perception of luminosity are eleven: doubt; failure to engage in mental attention; bodily misconduct; sleep and torpor; excessive diligence in effort; insufficient diligence in effort; absence of joy and confidence; diverse and scattered perceptions; speaking far too much; and fixating on forms with determined conceptual grasping.

What interrupts the perception of freedom from attachment is pervasive attachment.

What interrupts the perception of cessation is following after the signs of phenomena.

What interrupts the perception of death is being distracted by life.

Venerable ones, the three qualities that thoroughly overcome the undefeated interruptions are: valuing those three qualities, abandoning desire for them, and dwelling extensively in that.

Venerable ones, the fourteen qualities that attend to the perception of the unattractive are these: not dwelling together with women; keeping close mindfulness when looking at women; carefulness; having little attachment; not pursuing the signs of the attractive; examining the unattractive in detail; not associating with persons who have gone to the extreme of unwholesome action; not conforming to them; listening respectfully; inquiring thoroughly; guarding the doors of the senses; knowing the right measure in food; delighting in solitude; and examining things as they actually are.

Venerable ones, if the perception of the unattractive is cultivated, practiced, and repeatedly developed, desire for sensual objects will be abandoned. If the

perception of impermanence is cultivated, practiced, and repeatedly developed, formations will be abandoned. If the perception of suffering in what is impermanent is cultivated, practiced, and repeatedly developed, laziness and regret will be abandoned. If the perception of selflessness in suffering is cultivated, practiced, and repeatedly developed, the view of self will be abandoned. If the perception of the unsuitability of food is cultivated, practiced, and repeatedly developed, craving for flavors will be abandoned. If the perception of non-delight in the entire world is cultivated, practiced, and repeatedly developed, aspiration for and attachment to the various things of the world will be abandoned. If the perception of luminosity is cultivated, practiced, and repeatedly developed, wisdom will be seen. If the perception of freedom from attachment is cultivated, practiced, and repeatedly developed, all attachment will be abandoned. If the perception of cessation is cultivated, practiced, and repeatedly developed, the aggregates will be exhausted. If the perception of death is cultivated, practiced, and repeatedly developed, being distracted by life will be abandoned.

Venerable ones, there are twenty qualities that constitute interruptions for the noble śrāvaka who is practicing and behaving properly in accordance with that. They are these: not being diligent; associating with those who are not diligent; not inquiring thoroughly; being mute as a sheep when confronted with uncongenial scriptural transmission and conduct; being given to craving; having many tasks; having gone to the extreme of unwholesome action; abandoning effort; becoming despondent and proud upon hearing of interruptions; holding things to be uncongenial; being forgetful; being heedless; not dwelling in the domain of practice; having cultivated guarding through the senses; not knowing the right measure in food; not striving in practice by not sleeping in the first and last parts of the night; not delighting in solitude; and not examining things as they actually are.

Venerable ones, there are eleven qualities that thoroughly overcome those undefeated interruptions by attending to them. They are these: obtaining desire; seeing benefit; being genuinely joyful; being expansive and victorious; following the signs of phenomena; not disparaging oneself; listening respectfully; inquiring thoroughly; delighting in solitude; and examining things as they actually are.

Venerable ones, the twenty qualities that attend to the noble śrāvaka who practices proper mental attention in that way are these: being diligent; associating with those who are diligent;

having a scripture and a tradition consonant with thorough inquiry; not being mute like a sheep; being free of craving; not having many activities; having brought one's tasks to a proper conclusion; not having abandoned effort; not being disheartened upon hearing of interruptions; holding things in accord with what is not excessive; the establishing of mindfulness; being conscientious; dwelling in one's proper domain; guarding the doors of the sense faculties; knowing the measure in food; striving in practice during both the first and last parts of the night without sleeping; delighting in solitude; and examining things as they actually are.

Venerable ones, these twenty-two qualities are those which one who has gone forth should examine again and again. This quality in particular — "I have abandoned the marks of a householder; I am one of unpleasant appearance" — is one that one who has gone forth should examine again and again.

"I have taken on a different status; my deportment and conduct are other than before. My livelihood depends upon others. For as long as I live, it will be like this: robes, alms-food, lodging, medicine for illness, and requisites must be sought from others. For as long as I live, I have turned away from the desires of people. For as long as I live, I have turned away from the pleasures of sport and amusement enjoyed by people.

"Have I not disparaged myself by means of my own moral discipline? Have those of equal conduct in the holy life, the wise ones, not disparaged me on account of the nature of the Dharma itself? Do I conduct myself without having been disparaged and without having declined? Do I eat the alms-food of the surrounding village in a meaningful way? Do I delight in dwelling alone in an empty grove? How do I pass day and night in whatever state I am in?

"Has my mind entered into, grown clear about, come to properly rest in, and become fully liberated in the nirvāṇa that is the stilling of all formations, the perception of emptiness, the exhaustion of craving, and the passing beyond sorrow free of attachment?

"Has my mind entered into, grown clear about, come to properly rest in, and become fully liberated in the understanding that the aggregates are impermanent, that the aggregates are to be maintained, and that the aggregates are without essence?

"When I am dying, if those of equal conduct in the holy life, the wise ones, question me, will I give authoritative testimony, declaring correctly, without

embarrassment and without fear, something that is not beside the point — namely, will I have attained any one of the four fruits of the monk's life?

"I am of the nature of birth; I have not gone beyond the nature of birth. I am of the nature of aging. I am of the nature of illness. I am of the nature of death. I will come to be separated from, to be without, and to be deprived of everything desirable, beloved, cherished, and pleasing.

"I am to make karma my own. I am born of karma, partake of karma's inheritance, and am sustained by karma. Whatever virtuous or non-virtuous karma I perform, of that very karma I shall be the heir."

This is a quality that one who has gone forth should examine again and again. By examining these twenty-two qualities again and again, one's perception of the ascetic life becomes fully complete. When the perception of the ascetic life is fully complete, seven perceptions become fully complete: persevering continuously; engaging continuously; being free of covetousness and ill will; having correct mindfulness; being free of conceit; and having the means of livelihood as their own purpose along with mastery in meditative absorption — these become fully complete.

Venerable ones, whatever mind, mentation, and consciousness have long been attached to form, attached to sound,

attached to smell, attached to taste, attached to touch — all that has been accumulated and closely gathered through forms, sounds, smells, tastes, and tangible objects — upon individual examination, that will not be established as resting close to the deathless realm (nirvāṇa). Venerable ones, an ordinary person should cultivate weariness of mind through these twenty aspects: "I am one who stores up through understanding, yet I will die untamed. I will fall into the abyss. I will go toward the side where there is fear, and I do not know the side where there is no fear. I do not know karma. I have not attained meditative absorption. Further existence is suffering. A favorable leisure and endowment are hard to find. I am perpetually bound, as desires slay me. I have not passed beyond the destinies. I have not been fully liberated from the lower realms. I am possessed of innumerable and complete wrong views. I have not erected an obstacle to keep myself from committing the deeds of immediate retribution. I have not brought the cycle of birth, which has no beginning and no end, to its end. If it is not brought to its end, there is no other agent to do so. If it has not been done, there is no experience of happiness. The actions one has performed are not wasted. I have become ignorant, am

unskilled, and will meet with the time of death." Thus should an ordinary person cultivate weariness of mind. When, through those twenty aspects, one is deeply weary, deeply frightened, and deeply checked, then through another twenty aspects the mind becomes swiftly and correctly established. That is to say, the mind becomes swiftly and correctly established in attending to the sign of mind. The mind becomes swiftly and correctly established through attending to the sign of the supreme mind, or of the one-pointed mind, or the sign of meditative absorption, or the sign of abiding in meditative absorption, or the sign of arising from meditative absorption, or the sign of calm abiding, or the sign of firm grasping, or the sign of equanimity, or abandoning what is not one's domain of conduct, or devoting oneself to one's domain of conduct, or summary exposition, or removal by means of an object of meditation, or the abundance of thorough weariness, or reliance on a teacher, or the mind's swiftly and correctly resting through attending to correct application. The mind becomes swiftly and correctly established in the meditation of mindfulness of in-breath and out-breath. The mind becomes swiftly and correctly established in meditating on the establishments of mindfulness.

Venerable ones, the factors that interrupt a noble śrāvaka who has in that way attended correctly and in accordance with the teaching — cutting off of oneself — are to be understood as eleven: repeatedly gathering in groups; being addicted to food and taking delight in tasks; taking delight in talking; taking delight in idle chatter; taking delight in bustle; taking delight in activity; self-grasping; conceit; heedlessness; and not abiding in one's domain.

Venerable ones, the ten skills in which one must train in order to fully overcome those factors of interruption that have not been overcome are to be understood as follows: skill in meditative absorption; skill in abiding in meditative absorption; skill in arising from meditative absorption; skill in firm grasping; skill in equanimity; skill in sense bases; skill in skillful means; and skill in direct accomplishment.

Venerable ones, when a noble śrāvaka who is thus skilled in direct accomplishment arises, thirteen things that are objects of supreme delight are born. When one who has faith attends to the Teacher, or the Dharma, or the Saṅgha, or one's own ethical conduct, or another's ethical conduct, or the objects of one's own generosity, or one's own understanding, or another's understanding — when supreme delight arises in this, this is called an object of supreme delight for one who has faith.

When supreme delight arises in the thought "the Blessed One has removed my many phenomena of suffering," this is called an object of supreme delight for one who has faith. When supreme delight arises in the thought "the Blessed One has accomplished my many phenomena of happiness," this is called an object of supreme delight for one who has faith. When supreme delight arises in the thought "the Blessed One has removed my many sinful and non-virtuous phenomena," this is called an object of supreme delight for one who has faith. When supreme delight arises in the thought "the Blessed One has accomplished my many virtuous phenomena," this is called an object of supreme delight for one who has faith.

Venerable ones, if a noble śrāvaka relies upon four qualities of the Dharma, five qualities will be perfected in cultivation: aspiration, diligence, seclusion, and non-regression. As for those five qualities that will be perfected in cultivation, they are: supreme delight, joy, pliancy, bliss, and meditative absorption.

Venerable ones, when those five qualities are fully gathered and accumulated, eight thorns will be absent. They are as follows: the thorn of attachment, the thorn of aversion, the thorn of delusion, the thorn of pride, the thorn of craving, the thorn of views, and the thorn of doubt and suspicion.

When those eight thorns have been removed, ten qualities of one beyond training are attained: right view of one beyond training, right thought, right speech, right limit of action, right livelihood, right effort, right mindfulness, right meditative absorption, right liberation, and right wisdom.

When those ten qualities of one beyond training arise, are attained, and are possessed, one gains the noble attainment of having abandoned the five factors, being endowed with six factors, guarded by a single guarding, endowed with four supports, having set aside one's own truth, having set aside that setting aside, and being free from the turbidity of conceptual elaboration.

Translator's Notes

- The phrase "not having committed actions at the extreme" renders a technical formulation referring to the five actions of immediate retribution (ānantarya-karma) and similar extreme negative deeds; the Tibetan is slightly compressed here and different commentaries parse it somewhat differently.

The list of twenty ways of speaking contains several compressed paired terms. The rendering follows the most natural reading of the sequence, though the exact grouping of some items is not always unambiguous in the source text.

The phrase translated "inspiring heartfelt compassion in others" as the twelfth leisure-condition is unusual doctrinally; it may refer to having others who compassionately support one's practice, rather than oneself inspiring compassion. The Tibetan is ambiguous and no single reading is certain.

- The phrase rendered "the aggregates being accumulated" translates a term meaning "the aggregates as heaped up or accumulated," which alludes to the etymology of the Sanskrit word *skandha* as a "heap" or "accumulation." This is the standard Abhidharma doctrinal point being evoked here.

The phrase rendered "bodily misconduct" for *lus kyi gnas ngan len* is literally "the bad state or bad habit of the body," which in context refers to poor physical comportment or bodily restlessness as an obstacle to the arising of the perception of luminosity.

- The phrase rendered "being mute as a sheep when confronted with uncongenial scriptural transmission and conduct" translates a Tibetan idiom for someone who, when faced with teaching or discipline that does not suit them, remains silent and unresponsive like a sheep — a classical image for passive non-engagement rather than active inquiry.

The count of twenty interruptions as listed in the text appears to yield fewer than twenty items by straightforward enumeration; the tradition occasionally groups or subdivides items differently, and the final tally may depend on how certain compound phrases are parsed. This is a minor textual discrepancy worth noting for editorial purposes but does not affect the doctrinal meaning.

- The phrase rendered as "the aggregates are to be maintained" translates a term meaning literally "the aggregates involve nourishment or sustenance," which in context refers to the fact that the aggregates require feeding and upkeep — a standard reflection on the burden of embodied existence. The reading is straightforward within the commentarial tradition.

The list of seven perceptions at the close of the passage as it stands in the Tibetan appears to enumerate only six items explicitly before the text continues; the seventh may be partially embedded in the final compound. This is a minor structural ambiguity in the source and does not affect the doctrinal sense.

- The list of eleven interrupting factors contains a slight ambiguity: the Tibetan for "cutting off of oneself" renders a technical term likely equivalent to Sanskrit *ātmacchedana* or a related formation; the doctrinal sense is self-undermining behavior that cuts short meditative progress. The count of eleven items as listed in the Tibetan does not divide neatly without consulting the full commentary; the translation preserves the enumeration as given.

The list of ten skills as enumerated in the Tibetan appears to yield eight explicit items rather than ten; this discrepancy is present in the source text itself and may reflect a lacuna or condensed phrasing in this witness of the text.

- The passage enumerates "four qualities of the Dharma" on which a noble *śrāvaka* relies, but the text as it stands names only four results (aspiration, diligence, seclusion, non-regression) as the things "perfected," while the four Dharma qualities themselves are not spelled out here. This is a standard list in the Abhidharma literature; the four qualities are likely enumerated in the preceding section and this text assumes the listener already knows them.

The phrase "right limit of action" renders "*yang dag pa'i las kyi mtha'*" — the element "*mtha'*" (limit/culmination) is unusual in the standard eightfold path formula, where one expects simply "right action." Some canonical versions of this list substitute "right activity" or "right conduct"; the Tibetan here is literal and has been rendered as given.

The final compound — "having set aside one's own truth, having set aside that setting aside" — follows the Tibetan closely and reflects a technical formula describing the arhat's release from

all fixed standpoints, including the standpoint of renunciation itself.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.